

**The Combination of Military and Diplomatic Strategies in the Resolution of the Cuban
Missile Crisis**

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Military and Diplomatic Strategies and Resolution of the Cuban Missile Crisis

Introduction

In the vast conflicts of history, very few events have teetered on the brink of global catastrophe as the Cuban Missile Crisis did. Emerging from the tense backdrop of the Cold War, this confrontation in October 1962 brought the world to the edge of nuclear holocaust, demonstrating the harrowing potentiality of mutual destruction that came with a new age of nuclear weaponry. The crisis was a result of the placement of Soviet missiles in Cuba, sparking a showdown between superpowers and threatening to topple the sensitive balance of global power.

This research dives into the complex and varied dynamics that influenced the resolution of the Cuban Missile Crisis, examining the interplay between naval strategy and strength alongside the pivotal roles of diplomatic intelligence and the distinct personalities of and relationship between President John F. Kennedy and Premier Nikita Khrushchev. Naval strategy stood as a pillar of American strength and strategy during this historic confrontation, marked notably by the United States' establishment of a naval blockade around Cuba. Yet, arguably more important was the realm of diplomatic intelligence, where the intricate negotiations, communication channels, and decisions of key leaders was all happening against the backdrop of a potential nuclear armageddon. Furthermore, the distinct characters of Kennedy and Khrushchev, their temperaments, decision-making processes, and willingness to navigate a path away from conflict, emerged as vital in steering clear of mutual disaster.

By analyzing these factors, this paper argues that while diplomacy is always crucial in international conflicts, in the Cuban Missile Crisis, the combined influence of diplomatic intelligence and the personalities of Kennedy and Khrushchev played a larger role than solely naval strategy and strength in resolving the crisis on peaceful terms. This examination of the

Cuban Missile Crisis through a social and military historical perspective contributes to a deeper understanding of the complex interplay between international relations, individual personalities, and the importance of naval power in shaping the course of global conflicts and events.

Brief Naval History Leading to the Crisis

Between the Cuban Missile Crisis and World War II, the United States was deeply entrenched in the Cold War, an era characterized by the escalating tensions and strained relations with the Soviet Union (USSR). This period emerged following the end of World War II and was characterized by ideological, political, and military confrontations between the United States and the Soviet Union, both entrenched in the idea of global dominance geographically and ideologically. As a crucial arm of the U.S. military, the Navy assumed a pivotal role in this high-stakes geopolitical struggle. As tensions between the two superpowers intensified, the Navy's strategic significance expanded considerably. It evolved into a symbol of American strength, projecting power across crucial global regions, and served as a formidable deterrent against Soviet aggression.¹

Beyond its role in defense, the Navy played a multifaceted role in projecting American influence. Its global presence reassured allies in Europe and the Pacific, effectively containing the spread of communism and stabilizing regions susceptible to Soviet expansion. The Korean War epitomized the Navy's pivotal involvement; its dominance at sea and unwavering support for United Nations forces proved decisive in altering the conflict's trajectory.² By preventing costly withdrawals, facilitating troop movements, and disrupting enemy strategies, the Navy substantially impacted the outcomes on the ground, preserving independence and holding back

¹ James D. Hornfischer, *Who Can Hold the Sea: The U.S. Navy in the Cold War, 1945-1960* (New York: Bantam Books, 2023), 35.

² Edward Marolda, "The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991," *The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991*, 2020, <https://www.history.navy.mil/research/library/online-reading-room/title-list-alphabetically/n/the-navy-in-the-cold-war-era-1945-1991.html>.

encroaching Communist forces.³ The Navy's actions before the Cuban Missile Crisis were instrumental in executing containment strategies and actively participating in conflicts and crises. This pre-crisis period emphasized the Navy's vital role in maintaining global stability, shaping Cold War geopolitics, and safeguarding the United States' strategic interests.⁴

Navigating the evolving landscape of potential Third World War planning, the Navy underwent strategic adaptations, recognizing the significance of nuclear capabilities. Initially prioritizing the bolstering of conventional forces while acknowledging the rising importance of nuclear weapons, the Navy later adjusted its strategies to align with the era of all-out nuclear war preparations, an adopted strategy that would come after the Cuban Missile Crisis. This transformation involved the integration of nuclear-powered submarines and ballistic missile-equipped vessels into its arsenal.⁵

Amid mounting nuclear tensions, a nuanced approach emerged, moving beyond sole reliance on 'massive retaliation.'⁶ The Navy emphasized a more flexible response, blending conventional and nuclear capabilities for deterrence. These strategic evolutions mirrored the changing dynamics of nuclear warfare that encompassed the Cuban Missile Crisis, emphasizing the imperative of an adaptive naval strategy to effectively deter adversaries while preserving global stability.⁷

The U.S. Navy's strategic deterrence, global power projection, technological innovation, and crisis management efforts before the Cuban Missile Crisis demonstrated its pivotal role in

³ Edward Marolda, "The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991," *The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991*, 2020, <https://www.history.navy.mil/research/library/online-reading-room/title-list-alphabetically/n/the-navy-in-the-cold-war-era-1945-1991.html>.

⁴ Edward Marolda, "The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991,"

⁵ David Alan Rosenberg, "American Naval Strategy in the Era of the Third World War: An Inquiry into the Structure and Process of General War at Sea, 1945-90," *Naval Power in the Twentieth Century*, 1996, 242-54, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-349-13860-9_19, 4.

⁶ Rosenberg, "American Naval Strategy in the Era of the Third World War", 245

⁷ Rosenberg, "American Naval Strategy in the Era of the Third World War", 253

shaping US-USSR dynamics and positioning itself as a staunch defender against Soviet aggression. This pre-Cuban Missile Crisis period highlighted the critical role of the Navy in safeguarding American interests and influencing the delicate balance of power during the intense Cold War rivalry, a role that continued even beyond the pivotal events of 1962. Armed with advanced warships, cutting-edge aircraft, and highly skilled personnel, the Navy stood at the forefront of a comprehensive "containment strategy,"⁸ forming a protective shield around the Communist world and significantly influencing Cold War geopolitics.

Naval Strategy in the Cuban Missile Crisis

During the Cuban Missile Crisis, the US Navy assumed a pivotal role in navigating the complexities of international law, military strategy, and diplomatic efforts. Curtis A. Utz's "Cordon of Steel" describes how the Navy's various contributions were instrumental in containing the crisis.⁹ A focal point of the Navy's involvement lay in enforcing the naval quarantine, effectively creating a naval blockade to prevent Soviet shipments of missiles to Cuba. This operation showcased the Navy's strategic intelligence and operational efficiency in monitoring and intercepting Soviet vessels, forcing the eventual withdrawal of the missiles, and ultimately diffusing the immediate crisis. Utz's analysis emphasizes the Navy's intelligence-gathering capabilities, further emphasizing its critical role in providing essential information about Soviet movements and missile deployments.¹⁰ The intelligence obtained by Navy reconnaissance aircraft and submarines significantly informed the decision-making processes within the Kennedy administration. This intelligence network was crucial in

⁸ Edward Marolda, "The Navy in the Cold War Era, 1945-1991,"

⁹ Curtis A. Utz, *Cordon of Steel: The U.S. Navy and the Cuban Missile Crisis* (Honolulu: University Press of the Pacific, 1993), 63.

¹⁰ Utz, *Cordon of Steel*, 67.

understanding the depth of the threat posed by the Soviet Union and formulating an effective response.¹¹

Beyond the blockade itself, “The Cuban Missile Crisis: Strategy Formulation in Action” a broader significance of the Navy's presence in the Atlantic and elsewhere. The Navy's readiness and flexibility reassured allies and acted as a deterrent against potential Soviet aggression, extending beyond the Cuban situation to prevent a wider conflict. This illuminates the adaptability of the Navy, highlighting its ability to pivot strategies swiftly in response to emerging scenarios, ensuring a continuous state of preparedness throughout the tense standoff, an important factor in crisis resolution.¹²

Pivoting away from the Navy's significance, Morris Morley's “The United States and the Global Economic Blockade of Cuba” intricately explores the United States' quest to impose an economic blockade on Cuba, notably through trade and transport restrictions. While it acknowledges America's commitment to curbing Cuba's economic engagements, it notably downplays the naval blockade's significance as the main aspect in resolving the Cuban Missile Crisis. Focusing on the ramifications of economic and transport constraints on Cuba, it sheds light on endeavors aimed at limiting Cuba's trade with nations like the United Kingdom, Greece, and Lebanon.¹³ This underscores the decline in capitalist-bloc vessels involved in Cuban commerce and visits to Cuban ports from these nations, showcasing the economic strain inflicted by the U.S. naval blockade, though not necessarily the military's role.

¹¹ Helge Granfelt, "Sea Blockade as a Political Weapon," *Nordisk Tidsskrift for International Ret* 34 (1964), 139

¹² Grattan, R.F. (2004), "The Cuban missile crisis: strategy formulation in action", *Management Decision*, Vol. 42 No. 1, pp. 55-68. <https://doi.org/10.1108/00251740410504421>

¹³ Morley, Morris H. “The United States and the Global Economic Blockade of Cuba: A Study in Political Pressures on America's Allies.” *Canadian Journal of Political Science/Revue Canadienne De Science Politique* 17, no. 1 (1984): 25–48. doi:10.1017/S0008423900051246, 31.

The article specifically accentuates diplomatic efforts in rallying allied nations to curtail their shipments to Cuba, emphasizing the criticality of international collaboration in enforcing the blockade. However, while the data emphasizes the economic impact on Cuba's trade, it significantly underplays the naval blockade's role in resolving the Cuban Missile Crisis. Rather, it underscores a comprehensive strategy that leans heavily on economic constraints and diplomatic overtures to isolate Cuba.¹⁴ By steering attention away from the naval blockade's significance, the focus shifts toward diplomatic maneuvers as the driving force in the crisis resolution.

However, while Morley's analysis doesn't singularly attribute the resolution of the crisis to the naval blockade, it intertwines this aspect within a comprehensive strategy. The imposition of economic restrictions and diplomatic efforts to isolate Cuba, as highlighted in the decline of trade ties with capitalist countries and diplomatic negotiations, complemented the naval blockade. This collective approach significantly contributed to diffusing the crisis without resorting to armed conflict.¹⁵

Moreover, the memoirs of Soviet submarine commanders offer intriguing insights into the various challenges they faced en route to Cuba. These accounts vividly illustrate the extensive surveillance measures employed by the US Navy, showcasing the intricacy and intensity of naval operations during the crisis. The encounters between Soviet submarines and US naval vessels underline the rigorous efforts made by the Navy to counter the Soviet mission, highlighting the depth of challenges posed to the Soviet submarines.¹⁶

¹⁴ Morley, "The United States and the Global Economic Blockade of Cuba" 46

¹⁵ Morley, "The United States and the Global Economic Blockade of Cuba" 46

¹⁶ Ryurik A Ketov Captain 1st Rank, Russian Navy (retired) (2005) The Cuban Missile Crisis as Seen Through a Periscope, *Journal of Strategic Studies*, 28:2, 217-231, DOI: 10.1080/01402390500088304

Collectively, these perspectives underline the multi-dimensional nature of the Cuban Missile Crisis and the pivotal role played by the US Navy in maintaining global stability. The Navy's strategic enforcement of the blockade, intelligence capabilities, readiness, and adaptability significantly contributed to preventing further escalation and achieving a peaceful resolution to one of the most tense moments of the Cold War.

Role of Character and Relationships in the Crisis

During the peak of the Cold War, the relationships and distinct personalities of President Kennedy and Premier Khrushchev played a pivotal role in navigating the world through the horror of the Cuban Missile Crisis. The events leading to this historic confrontation were rooted in the intensifying tensions between the United States and the Soviet Union, tensions that both leaders wanted to cool.

In a 1961 letter to Khrushchev, Kennedy appealed to Khrushchev by admitting that despite their differences and inability to agree on some things, their relationship was still important. Kennedy's letter to Khrushchev, with its diplomatic overtones and an underlying desire for open communication, is a demonstration of the relationship between the two global leaders and a window into Kennedy's personality. Although it didn't directly impact the outset of the Cuban Missile Crisis, its message of diplomacy and dialogue set a tone that would echo in the future interactions between the leaders.¹⁷

During the crisis, this amicable tone would waver. Kennedy's careful and measured demeanor contrasted sharply with Khrushchev's impulsive nature, laying the foundation for both tension and a crucial channel of communication during the crisis.¹⁸ Khrushchev's erratic behavior

¹⁷ Kennedy, "Letter From President Kennedy to Chairman Khrushchev," U.S. Department of State, 1961, <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1961-63v06/d7>.

¹⁸ Blight, James G., Janet M. Lang, and Koji Masutani. *The armageddon letters: Kennedy/Khrushchev/Castro in the Cuban Missile Crisis*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2015, 96.

during the crisis complicated negotiations. His shifting demands and unpredictability posed significant challenges.¹⁹ Despite his bold decision to deploy missiles in Cuba, indicative of his assertiveness, Khrushchev displayed a willingness to negotiate when faced with the terrifying prospect of a nuclear confrontation. As the situation escalated, Kennedy's deliberate approach and readiness to engage in direct communication aligned with the essence of his earlier correspondence.²⁰ These private and public exchanges, through television broadcasts and written letters, mirrored the diplomatic tone suggested in the letter and became an important part in managing the heightening tensions and diffusing the crisis.

"Russian and Soviet History" offers profound insights into Khrushchev's personality. It portrays him as impulsive yet capable of engaging in dialogue. His assertiveness set the crisis in motion, while his pragmatism facilitated its resolution. This complex interplay of personalities proved instrumental in steering the world away from the brink of nuclear disaster.²¹

To understand the depth of this crisis, one must recognize the broader context of the Cold War. The ideological struggle between communism and democracy had intensified, creating a climate of suspicion and competition between the superpowers. This backdrop of ideological rivalry and strategic competition underscored the gravity of the Cuban Missile Crisis and magnified the significance of the personal dynamics between Kennedy and Khrushchev.²²

Therefore, the contrasting personalities of Kennedy and Khrushchev, amid the backdrop of intense geopolitical tensions, demonstrated the critical role of relationships and individual traits in shaping pivotal moments of history. Their distinct approaches—Kennedy's cautious

¹⁹ Blight, et al. *The armageddon letters: Kennedy/Khrushchev/Castro in the Cuban Missile Crisis*. 195.

²⁰ Mongar, Thomas M. "Personality and Decision-Making: John F. Kennedy in Four Crisis Decisions." *Canadian Journal of Political Science/Revue Canadienne De Science Politique* 2, no. 2 (1969): 200–225. doi:10.1017/S0008423900024896.

²¹ Usitalo, Steven A., and William Benton Whisenhunt. *Russian and Soviet history: From The Time of Troubles to the collapse of the Soviet Union*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2008.

²² SCHERER, JOHN L. "Reinterpreting Soviet Behavior during the Cuban Missile Crisis." *World Affairs* 144, no. 2 (1981): 110–25. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/20671888>. .

diplomacy and Khrushchev's assertive yet negotiable stance—proved pivotal in steering the world away from a potential nuclear catastrophe, highlighting how personal characteristics impacted global events during this critical period of the Cold War.

Diplomatic Intelligence of Kennedy and Khrushchev

During the peak of the Cuban Missile Crisis, the intricate choreography of diplomatic exchanges between President Kennedy and Premier Khrushchev became the pivotal force steering the world clear of an impending cataclysmic nuclear cataclysm. Within this historical era, the significance of diplomatic dialogue and communication in foreign policy, especially amid the high-stakes tension characterizing the missile crisis, came to the forefront.²³

The interactions and negotiations that unfolded between Kennedy and Khrushchev during this tense period were far more than mere conversations; they were strategic maneuvers that held immense sway over their intentions and actions.²⁴ Navigating these dialogues posed a difficult task as both leaders had motives to hide their true intentions, fostering an atmosphere steeped in mutual suspicion.²⁵ Deciphering the authenticity behind their statements became an indispensable compass through the treacherous terrain of the crisis. The weighty influence of diplomatic exchanges as influential speech acts impeccably aligns with the instrumental role played by Kennedy and Khrushchev's communications in defusing the crisis. Their messages, encompassing content, tone, and context, wielded decisive power in shaping perceptions, recalibrating intentions, and, most importantly, averting an unimaginable nuclear conflict.²⁶

²³ Medland, William J. "The Cuban Missile Crisis: Evolving Historical Perspectives." *The History Teacher* 23, no. 4 (1990): 433–47. <https://doi.org/10.2307/494397>.

²⁴ Kahan, Jerome H., and Anne K. Long. "The Cuban Missile Crisis: A Study of Its Strategic Context." *Political Science Quarterly* 87, no. 4 (1972): 564–90. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2148197>.

²⁵ Timothy Naftali, Khrushchev and Kennedy, *Diplomatic History*, Volume 42, Issue 4, September 2018, Pages 532–535, <https://doi.org/10.1093/dh/dhy04>

²⁶ Timothy Naftali, Khrushchev and Kennedy, *Diplomatic History*, Volume 42, Issue 4, September 2018, Pages 532–535, <https://doi.org/10.1093/dh/dhy045>

"Nuclear Folly: A New History of the Cuban Missile Crisis" very specifically scrutinizes the complex web of diplomatic exchanges and shared intelligence between Kennedy and Khrushchev, emphasizing their superior communication skills as the main factor in resolving the conflict. The meticulous analysis of their correspondences, covert communications, and negotiation strategies emphasizes the profound significance of these leaders in averting an impending disaster.²⁷ Underpinning the importance of establishing direct communication channels during the crisis, "Nuclear Folly" underscores Kennedy's clandestine correspondence with Khrushchev and the strategic deployment of backchannel diplomacy. These covert interactions afforded both leaders the platform to relay intentions, express concerns, and explore potential pathways for resolution away from the prying public eye.

The exhaustive analysis of these exchanges unequivocally underscores the pivotal role played by diplomatic acumen and adept negotiation in forestalling an escalation toward catastrophic conflict. Kennedy's astute grasp of the situation and his deft navigation of intricate diplomatic channels were pivotal in diffusing the crisis. His acute understanding of the perils entwined with nuclear conflict guided his decisions, underscoring the pivotal role of diplomatic intelligence in grasping the gravity of the situation. Kennedy's nuanced comprehension of Soviet motivations facilitated his approach, affording leeway for maneuvering without cornering Khrushchev. Opting for a blockade over military strikes showcased his diplomatic finesse, signaling seriousness while preserving space for peaceful resolutions. His adept orchestration of communications through diverse international forums showcased the monumental influence wielded by diplomatic intelligence in steering the crisis toward a peaceful resolution.²⁸

²⁷ Plokhy, Serhii. *Nuclear folly: A new history of the Cuban Missile Crisis*. London: Penguin Books, 2022, 346

²⁸ Robert F. Trager, "The Diplomacy of War and Peace," *Annual Review of Political Science* 19, no. 1 (2016): 205–28, <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-051214-100534>, 208.

Moreover, Kennedy's subtle offer to withdraw U.S. missiles from Turkey epitomized diplomatic finesse aimed at defusing tensions. In essence, the successful resolution of the crisis rested primarily on astute diplomatic intelligence, strategic negotiations, and Kennedy's nuanced understanding of Soviet intentions, averting a potentially catastrophic nuclear confrontation.²⁹

The resolution of the Cuban Missile Crisis bore the imprints of diplomatic intelligence intertwined with the unique personas of Kennedy and Khrushchev. Their intricate handling of communications, strategic negotiations, and profound grasp of each other's intentions stood as the pivotal factors in averting a potential nuclear armageddon, ultimately steering history away from the brink of war's perilous precipice.

Conclusion

This research encapsulated the crux of not only a geopolitical clash but also the intersection of maritime military history and social dynamics. It underscored the significance of naval strategies in shaping global affairs while illuminating the profound impact of diplomatic maneuvers and the human factor—the personalities and decision-making processes of leaders. The Cuban Missile Crisis, a pivotal moment in history that threatened global catastrophe, highlighted the critical interplay between naval strategy, diplomatic intelligence, and the personalities of Kennedy and Khrushchev. While naval strength and strategy formed a crucial aspect, diplomatic intelligence, and the leaders' distinct characters played a larger role in defusing the crisis. The U.S. Navy's role in containment strategies and its enforcement of the blockade were pivotal, but not singularly decisive in resolution. The personal dynamics between Kennedy and Khrushchev, rooted in careful diplomacy and assertiveness, navigated the crisis away from the nuclear brink. The intricate dance of diplomatic exchanges between them, shrouded in the challenge of deciphering true intentions, became instrumental in preventing

²⁹ Plokhyy, Serhii. *Nuclear Folly*, 295

catastrophe. Ultimately, the Cuban Missile Crisis was a testament to how diplomatic intelligence, strategic negotiations, and the leadership personas of Kennedy and Khrushchev averted a potential nuclear catastrophe, steering the course of history away from the perilous brink of war.

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